

EARLY PERCUSSION GUNS

A new way of priming a gun, by striking a small amount of chemical primer (a substance that ignites when struck), was invented in the 19th century. The first step toward this “percussion” system was taken by Alexander Forsyth, who developed a gunlock in which fulminate powder (the primer) was held in a magazine shaped like a scent bottle. Although this lock had advantages over the flintlock, loose fulminate was dangerous to use, so further devices were invented to contain just enough for priming a gun once. The evolution of percussion design culminated in the percussion cap (see pp.80–81). In the early 19th century, guns employed a variety of percussion locks, but the percussion cap had been almost universally adopted by the 1830s.



▲ BELGIAN DUELING PISTOL

Date 1830

Origin Belgium

Barrel 9¼in (23.8cm)

Caliber .31in (8mm)

Percussion-cap pistols were more reliable than even the best flintlocks, and one of their earliest uses was as dueling pistols. This half-stocked pistol by the gunmaker Folville, one of a cased pair, was made in Liège, Belgium, an internationally significant center of gunmaking at the time.